

GOLD RUSH IN HUNGARY

INDIA SWEPT BOTH THE OPEN AND WOMEN'S GOLD MEDALS AT THE 2024 FIDE CHESS OLYMPIAD IN BUDAPEST, MARKING A MONUMENTAL ACHIEVEMENT IN THE SPORT.

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Budapest, a city once synonymous with idyllic vacations, is fast becoming a landmark for triumphs and a place of many firsts for Indian sports. After Neeraj Chopra soared to World Athletics Championships gold here in javelin throw in 2023, the Indian chess teams have now scripted their own fairytale in the Hungarian capital.

Magyarország, the 'Land of Magyars,' offered a fitting stage to erase the ghosts of Mahabalipuram, where India fell short of the top prize two years ago. **This time, there was no stumbling — just pure dominance, as India sealed its legacy with double gold.**

From a total of 7,752 games played by 1,870 players across 11 rounds over 13 days, India's triumph is no small feat. After decades of Soviet dominance in the chess world, followed by Eastern Europe's rise post-1960, the nerve centre of chess seems to have shifted. India and the Central Asian nations now look poised to challenge the traditional powerhouses, and Chess Olympiad 2024 was a great example. Five Asian countries — India, Uzbekistan, China, Armenia, and Azerbaijan — secured



MARIA EMELIANOVA/FIDE

spots in the top eight of the Open section.

A similar pattern emerged in the women's section, with the same teams (excluding Azerbaijan) claiming top-seven finishes, signalling that this is no coincidence but rather the rise of new chess powers.

Leading this transformative wave is the young Indian contingent, whose consistent performances have captivated the world.

Coming in as the second seed